

Short Introduction to Philosophy - Subject: We are Awake

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Section I: Introduction

In this paper, I will challenge the author's claim that it is impossible to know that I am sitting down reading. The author argues that I can't know that I am sitting down reading since the possibility that I'm dreaming cannot be ruled out. In the first section, I will explain the author's argument. In the second section, I will argue against the first premise of the Dreaming Argument (DR1). In the third section, I will address a potential objection to my argument and provide a defense.

To start, consider "The Dreaming Hypothesis" (116). The example of reading a philosophy textbook is contextual and can be changed.

(TDH) You are currently lying down in bed dreaming about sitting down reading a philosophy textbook.

(Learning from Arguments, Korman 116)

The author's Dreaming Argument is as follows:

(DR1) If you have no way of knowing that TDH is false, then you don't know that you're sitting down reading.

(DR2) You have no way of knowing that TDH is false.

(DR3) So you don't know that you're sitting down reading.

(Learning from Arguments, Korman 116)

The idea behind DR1 is that without knowing that TDH is untrue, you are unable to know for sure if you are sitting down reading. You could just be dreaming about reading, and in reality, be lying asleep in your bed. To highlight why TDH must be considered, the author uses "The Competing Hypotheses Argument" (117) to argue that you must disprove all competing claims to know a certain thing. The argument can be seen here:

(CH1) One knows a certain thing only if one has some way of knowing that all competing hypotheses are false

(CH2) TDH is a hypothesis that competes with your belief that you're sitting down reading

(DR1) So, if you have no way of knowing that TDH is false, then you don't know that you're sitting down reading

(Learning from Arguments, Korman 117)

The author uses an example of a hawk to illustrate CH1 of this argument. Suppose you see a bird in the sky and claim that you know it is a hawk. Without disproving competing hypotheses like if the bird was an eagle or a falcon, you have no way of really knowing that it is a hawk. To know

for sure that it's a hawk, all competing hypotheses must be eliminated and ruled out. CH2 simply claims that TDH is a competing hypothesis to the belief that you are sitting down reading. Combining these two premises gives the basis for DR1, in which TDH needs to be ruled out to conclude that you know you are reading.

The second premise of the argument contends that there is no way to disprove TDH. The idea behind DR2 is that even while TDH may be a radical claim, you can't know if it's false, even if you don't believe it's true. One of the defenses presented by the author is the "No Useful Tests Argument" (123), which states that there are no reliable tests to confirm whether you are dreaming. Any test used to confirm you are awake could occur within a vivid dream that replicates the sensation of reality. For example, you could dream of pinching yourself and feeling pain, proving the common pinch test is unreliable for distinguishing between being awake and dreaming. Using the same logic for all dreaming tests demonstrates that there aren't any reliable tests to prove you are truly awake.

My aim in this paper is to show that even without rejecting all competing hypotheses like TDH, I can disprove DR1 by demonstrating that an active perception of my actions gives me enough evidence to justify knowledge.

Section II: Objection

The author's first premise, which asserts that you don't know you are sitting down reading because you cannot reject TDH, is flawed. My objection centers around the fact that TDH doesn't need to be rejected to prove that I know that I'm reading. Instead, I can know I'm reading because I am actively perceiving it, and that perception constitutes knowledge.

In order to reject DR1, I will first challenge CH1, which claims that knowledge requires ruling out all competing hypotheses. I argue that this condition is overly stringent and unrealistically demanding as a standard for knowing something. Consider the author's hawk example from Section I. If I observe a bird with all the typical characteristics of a hawk, my claim in knowing that it's a hawk is justified. However, competing hypotheses will still always exist, such as the possibility of the bird being an abnormal eagle that perfectly mimics a hawk's behaviors and physical characteristics. Yet, these alternatives are so improbable and difficult to rule out that they do not realistically undermine my claim of knowledge. The features I perceive, such as its size, shape, and flight pattern, provide strong justification for my belief that I know the bird is a hawk. Therefore, CH1's requirement to rule out every possible competing hypothesis is both impossible and unnecessary for knowledge.

Building on my argument, consider the act of typing this essay. As I type, I am directly perceiving myself doing it, and I can confidently say that I know I am typing. This knowledge does not depend on ruling out every competing hypothesis, such as the possibility that I am

dreaming of typing. Rather, it is grounded in the immediacy of my perception, which provides me with direct knowledge of my current actions. While typing this essay, I experienced the act in real-time, offering a level of certainty that goes beyond hypothetical reasoning. The experience of perception itself becomes a form of knowledge. Although TDH suggests that my current reality could be different from what I perceive, it doesn't undermine the validity of the knowledge I gain through perception. Therefore, if I can perceive myself reading, then I can confidently know I am reading and reject the author's claim in DR1 that I need to know that TDH is false.

Section III: Rebuttal

In this section, I will address a potential objection to my argument. One could argue that without rejecting TDH and all other competing hypotheses, my understanding of knowledge and reality would be weak. The slim possibility that I would wake up and realize I've dreamt all the past events that just occurred shows that my perception could be deceived. If I can't rule out the possibility that I am dreaming, then any knowledge claim based on perception becomes vulnerable to doubt, making perception an unreliable foundation for knowledge. Therefore, unless I can conclusively disprove TDH, my perceptual beliefs don't constitute enough reliable evidence to know that I am reading.

However, I argue that my active perception is sufficient to justify a claim to knowledge without needing to reject weak competing hypotheses like TDH. Perception itself provides a plausible basis for understanding reality, making my knowledge valid even without ruling out all possible alternatives. Perception provides me with situational knowledge that is immediate and context-dependent, allowing me to know things like if I am reading or typing. For instance, imagine that I feel a sharp pain from stubbing my toe. The immediate perception of that pain gives me knowledge that I am currently in pain and I know that I'm in pain. The possibility that I am dreaming does not negate the pain I perceive. This demonstrates that perception is a reliable source of knowledge, as it provides direct insight into my current state, regardless of theoretical challenges like TDH. Thus, the knowledge gained through active perception is sufficient and I can know that I'm reading without knowing if TDH is false.

AI - Contribution Statement: I did not rely on AI at all when writing this paper.